ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Biotechnology English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For biotech scientists, translational researchers, assay-development teams, platform teams, program managers, alliance managers, business-development staff, and biotech executives.

Open this course on English Ladder

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

assay

Laboratory procedure used to measure the presence, amount, activity, or quality of a biological target.

biomarker

Measurable biological characteristic used to indicate a condition, response, exposure, or disease-related process.

CMC

Chemistry, manufacturing, and controls information that shows how a drug substance or product is made and consistently controlled.

comparability

The extent to which products, processes, or results are sufficiently similar for a stated purpose.

due diligence

Structured review of facts, risks, obligations, and evidence before a transaction, onboarding, investment, or decision.

exclusivity

An arrangement limiting specified rights or activities to one party for an agreed scope.

freedom to operate

Assessment of whether a product or activity can proceed without infringing another party's enforceable intellectual-property rights.

in vitro

Performed outside a living organism, typically in a laboratory vessel, cell system, or controlled assay.

in vivo

Performed in a living organism, such as an animal or human study participant.

inflection point

A stage at which the direction or pace of development may change significantly.

IP

Intellectual property: legally recognized rights in certain creations, inventions, and identifying marks.

material transfer agreement
An agreement setting conditions for transferring and using research materials.

milestone
A significant planned point or achievement used to track progress.

modality
A type of therapeutic or technological approach, such as a small molecule or cell therapy.

option
A possible course of action; in an agreement, a specified right that may be exercised.

patient stratification
Grouping patients by characteristics that may affect disease course, treatment response, safety, or trial analysis.

platform
A foundational technology or system that supports several applications or products.

proof of concept
Early evidence that an idea can work under specified conditions.

publication rights
The agreed rights and conditions governing disclosure or publication of work.

reproducibility
Obtaining consistent results using the same data and methods; conventions vary by research field.

risk mitigation
Action intended to reduce the likelihood or impact of a risk.

runway
In business, the time resources are expected to last under stated assumptions; in aviation, a takeoff and landing surface.

safety margin
The difference between a limit and an observed or expected value under a stated definition.

sensitivity
Ability of a test, model, or process to correctly identify true positives or detect a change in an input.

specificity

Ability of a test, model, or process to correctly identify true negatives and avoid false positives.

surrogate endpoint

Measure expected to predict clinical benefit but not itself a direct measure of how a patient feels, functions, or survives.

tech transfer

Controlled transfer of product, process, method, or manufacturing knowledge between teams, sites, or organizations.

term sheet

A summary of proposed transaction terms, whose binding effect depends on its wording and context.

toxicity

The capacity of a substance or exposure to cause harmful biological effects.

translatability

Likelihood that a finding in one model, setting, or population will predict results in the intended real-world or clinical setting.

validation

Confirming that an output or system meets needs for its intended use under defined conditions.

yield

The proportion of production meeting defined requirements; in finance, a return measure with a different calculation.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but ... .

Option A ..., whereas option B ... .

The comparison depends on ... .

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that ... .

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm ... .

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Platform Technology and Scientific Thesis

A platform produces a promising signal in one experimental system. An investor slide says it will work across several diseases.

The finding is promising in this experimental system. We have not established its relevance across diseases. I'll distinguish the current evidence from the broader platform hypothesis.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

02 | Assay Development and Reproducibility

An assay gives consistent results within one run but different results across three days. A colleague calls it fully reproducible.

Within-run consistency and performance across days are different questions. Let's report both and investigate the between-day variation before describing the assay as reproducible under those conditions.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

03 | Biomarkers and Translational Strategy

A team calls a biomarker "validated" without specifying whether it means analytical performance or clinical usefulness.

What kind of validation do you mean here? Could we distinguish the assay's analytical performance from evidence about the biomarker's clinical use? The slide needs to state which claim the data support.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

04 | Preclinical Data Packages

An animal study shows an effect at one tested exposure. A summary describes the result as proof of human benefit.

The result describes the tested animal model and exposure. It does not establish human benefit. I'll state the finding and the limits on translating it to a clinical setting.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

05 | CMC and Scale-Up in Biotech

A process transfer achieved the expected yield in two small runs. Performance at a larger scale remains untested.

The two small runs met the expected yield. Larger-scale performance is still untested. I'll present scale-up as an open question and identify the next planned evidence point.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

06 | IP, Freedom to Operate, and Collaboration

Two partners want to exchange materials. The draft arrangement leaves publication and permitted-use questions unresolved.

Could the responsible teams confirm the permitted uses and publication terms before the exchange? I'll summarize the scientific purpose and the unresolved questions for review.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

07 | Investor and Board Updates

A project update lists completed experiments but does not connect them to the next funding milestone.

I'll group the results around the milestone question: what have we learned, what remains uncertain, and what evidence is needed next? That will make the funding discussion easier to follow.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

08 | Partnering and Business Development

A potential partner requests exclusive rights before the scope of the collaboration is defined.

We can discuss exclusivity alongside the proposed scope, responsibilities, and milestones. Could we first clarify which activities and rights you have in mind so the appropriate teams can evaluate the request?

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice for professional communication. Clinical, safety, regulatory, and patient-care decisions follow qualified supervision and current local procedures.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.